

Imagine Sisyphus Happy: Camus and the Philosophy of the Absurd

An original lesson plan inspired by **David Simpson's** the Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Albert Camus. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy or David Simpson. Explore the original course: <https://iep.utm.edu/albert-camus/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

55 minutes

TOPICS

Existentialism

“Camus argues that the universe is fundamentally indifferent to our demand for meaning, yet concludes we must imagine the eternally-laboring Sisyphus happy rather than give up — is defiant revolt against a meaningless universe a rational response, or just a refusal to face the facts?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Define 'the absurd' as Camus presents it: the collision between the human demand for meaning and a universe that offers no ultimate answer.
- Explain why Camus rejects both suicide and a religious 'leap of faith' as adequate responses to the absurd, and reconstruct his alternative of lucid revolt.
- Apply the myth of Sisyphus to a real or invented modern scenario and evaluate whether Camus's claim — that meaning can be found in the struggle itself, without external justification — is ultimately convincing.

Materials Needed

- Excerpt handout with a short retelling of the Sisyphus myth plus Camus's opening claim that suicide is 'the one truly serious philosophical problem' and his closing image of imagining Sisyphus happy
- Handout summarizing the three responses to the absurd: suicide, the religious leap, and revolt
- Whiteboard for the hook activity
- Scenario cards describing modern repetitive or seemingly futile tasks for the application activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Endless Task

8 min

Describe a job that consists of digging a hole and immediately filling it back in, every day, forever, with no product and no end. Ask students: could a person doing this job actually be happy, or is happiness simply impossible under those conditions? Collect a range of answers on the board without resolving the question — this directly previews the Sisyphus myth.

Direct Instruction: The Absurd

15 min

Introduce Camus's concept of the absurd, not as a property of the world alone or of human consciousness alone, but as the confrontation between the two: we demand clarity and ultimate meaning, and the universe answers only with silence. Emphasize that for Camus, absurdity is a relationship, which is why it can be neither dissolved by fixing the world nor by changing our own psychology alone.

Text Analysis: Three Responses

17 min

In small groups, students read the excerpt and identify Camus's treatment of three possible responses to the absurd: (1) suicide, physically escaping the confrontation, which Camus rejects as failing to actually resolve anything; (2) the religious or philosophical 'leap of faith,' which Camus calls 'philosophical suicide' because it resolves the tension only by inventing an answer the absurd condition doesn't actually supply; and (3) revolt, living in full lucid awareness of the absurd without either escape, which Camus argues is the only response that takes the situation seriously. Groups should identify Camus's specific objection to each of the first two responses.

Small-Group Application

10 min

Using the scenario cards (a factory line, an endless email inbox, an unwinnable game), groups apply Camus's three responses and argue which one the person in their scenario is engaging in, and what 'revolt' would concretely look like for that person.

Closure: Imagining Sisyphus Happy

5 min

Read aloud Camus's closing image of imagining Sisyphus happy as he walks back down the mountain toward his boulder. Ask for a quick show of hands: is this a genuinely satisfying answer to the absurd, or is Camus just declaring victory over a problem he hasn't actually solved?

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is Camus right that a 'leap of faith' toward religious or philosophical certainty is a form of evasion, or can such a leap be a reasonable response to a genuinely unanswerable question?
- 2 Can revolt against the absurd really be sustained forever, moment to moment, or does Camus's 'happy Sisyphus' require occasionally forgetting the absurd rather than facing it?
- 3 Does finding meaning in the struggle itself, without any external justification, actually count as finding meaning — or is Camus redefining 'meaning' down to something smaller than what we originally wanted?
- 4 Is the demand for ultimate meaning that creates the absurd condition itself something we could simply give up, or is it as fundamental to being human as Camus assumes?

- 5 Can you think of a real modern task or job that mirrors Sisyphus's — repetitive, seemingly without ultimate point — and does the person doing it seem more like Camus's 'happy' Sisyphus or like someone in despair?

Assessment

Students write a short response applying Camus's three responses to the absurd (suicide, the leap, revolt) to a real or invented scenario of their own choosing, arguing which response the person in their scenario adopts and whether Camus's image of a 'happy Sisyphus' is a satisfying resolution or merely a hopeful slogan.

Extension Activity

Have students research one specific historical or public figure Camus is often associated with resisting or admiring (for instance, figures in the French Resistance) and write a short analysis of how the concept of 'revolt' as lucid, sustained defiance without illusion might apply to that figure's real actions.

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